

burners-principles

Burners Principles

The rules in [[Burners Adventure Game]] and the satellite books are built on a short list of design commitments. They are the spine behind every subsystem — combat, magic, gear, social play, and porting OSE modules. When a corner case arises, ask which principle the moment serves, then route it through the subsystem that already implements it.

Two engines

The World Engine is how the world behaves on its own terms. People, monsters, and places have a nature that does not bend to a wish.

The Hero Engine is how you act: you say what you do and roll for what it costs.

Player skill decides whether the world bends; your Approach decides only how much effect you have. A good idea, well told, makes things happen. Your sheet makes them happen harder. It never makes the impossible possible.

Dice only when there is a price. The dice come out when a Cost is on the table — Heat, HP, time, noise, position, or a Spicy twist. A safe and certain action just happens. There is no Persuade roll for whether the world bends; that is Step 1. Heart amplifies a success the fiction already grants; it never manufactures an impossible one.

Granular defense, not binary save

Burners has no save-or-die. Endurance is **Defend** — a graded contest, not a gate you pass or fail.

- **Out of combat**, a hazard is **2d6 + the fitting Approach** against the Referee's Cost. You may soften the price, bear it whole, or dodge it clean — but the outcome is a matter of degree, not a single on/off switch.
- **In combat**, blows land. You **commit Fuel dice** and cut incoming damage by their faces; a Burner's armor soaks the rest; what remains comes off HP. Unlimited Defend (once you have meleed), Cover (2 dice vs missiles), Block (redirect onto yourself), and Riposte are ways to answer a blow — not a roll that erases the hit. Monsters soak with Resistance only.

- **Hostile magic** uses the same Fuel economy as steel. The caster's **cast total** (sum of faces spent to cast) opposes your **defense total** (sum of faces you commit). Partial defense means partial effect: **overrun** = cast – defense, applied as harm to HP *or* as the spell's hold — never both. There is no “save for half” — you defended as well as your dice allowed.

A binary save asks *did you avoid it?* Burners asks *how much did you stop, and what is left?*

Procedure: *Defend* in [[Burners Adventure Game]]; *Defending against a spell* in [[Burners Sorcerie]]; *The Defend Router* in [[Burners OSE Conversions]].

Attrition, not spike damage

Lethality lives in **attrition and ambush**, not in big single numbers. Your Fuel only shrinks over a fight; when it runs dry, blows arrive whole. Surprise skips the exchange — a foe you never saw strikes a Fuel you have not rolled.

Past 0 HP, blows open **Wounds**; each is a Shock Check (combat-effective). After the fight, unhelped Wounds kill; helped, a Craft survival check decides. The stack and the survival roll kill you — not a single failed save, not the passage of time alone.

Steel and sorcery share the same pool. The danger is the turn you are winded with workings still flying.

Taking foes out: chip to 0 so the next blow wounds and fells; one-shots only against the genuinely weak. Mooks fall fast; bosses are a siege.

HP is plot armor; past 0 it gets real

HP is plot armor — luck, wind, near-misses. Blows come off HP and you shrug them. Nothing is torn yet.

Past **0**, the shit gets real. Overflow opens a **Wound**: a negative tally that is your actual flesh, a location, an effect, a Shock Check for combat footing.

Reach full HP and every wound closes — tally, penalties, soft-target marks. Maimings offered at the brink are the exception.

Death lands after the fight — **unhelped Wound, failed Craft survival, or a coup de grace** on a helpless body — not from classic level loss, and not from Shock alone.

Heat is scene pressure

Heat is one shared gauge for the whole crew — the temperature of the scene, not any one body's flesh. It prices most out-of-combat Costs and clocks when a job turns dangerous.

- Heat is **never a damage buffer**; blows in a fight go to HP, not Heat.
 - Heat **feeds the monster pool once** on Initiative (one die per point, enemy side).
Don't double-count dread: the creature's HD, weapon, and Resistance are its own; Heat prices only the situation — the dark, the alarm, the flanking.
 - Module foreshadowing is mechanical: boxed danger is a **Heat raise**; rooms that let the party prepare are Heat reductions waiting to be claimed.
 - When the party splits, each live scene runs its own Heat.
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Earned in play

Traits come with levels; **Signatures**, named gear, and spell learning are **never bought with XP**. They emerge at the table — one Signature per level in that Approach.

Magic arms and armor are looted or earned, never bought at creation. Magic items grant **0 XP**; the item is the reward. Enchanted = legendary = eldritch: a *+1* is a magic sword. It **accepts** only a matching Trait (no roll) — extra die and powers once found: `[[Burners Adventure Game#Enchanted Arms and Armor]]`. How you stock and convert them: `[[Burners Referee Magic Items]]`.

Invocations are not Sorcerie

An **Invocation** is a bargain, not a spell. No Arcana, no spellbook, no school Trait. **Patron Alignment** is not Sorcerie level — a torch-hand may be Lunara 3 and never cast; a Sorcerer may know every school and stand a stranger to every god.

Not wishes. Players will reach for Invocations whenever they are stuck — Wåndyr taught that the hard way. The **Cost roll** gates whether a patron hears you; the **Offer and Ask** are where the Referee balances what you get against what you owe. Neither is a menu for rewriting the scene.

Sweet and Spicy vs Spark

Out of combat, **Sweet** (6) and **Spicy** (1) ride alongside the sum and never change it. Double Sweet is the perfect roll; double Spicy is a fumble.

Combat has no Sweet or Spicy. There you read the dice you spend; a 6 is a **Spark** — a second action you still pay for from Fuel.

Sword owns the press

In combat, only **Sword** answers. The diplomat, locksmith, and archmage are bodies in the melee until they escape the press. Spend other mastery before blades draw — ambush, parley, ward, position.

Pools, not fixed numbers

Creatures fight like characters. On Initiative they roll a **Fuel pool** and spend dice to attack, defend, Spark, and Riposte. A blow is the **faces of the dice committed** — cut by defense and armor — not a fixed Damage stat on a stat block. There are no to-hit rolls; the pool carries how hard and how often a foe strikes.

Spells work the same way: cast at least L Fuel dice; the **cast total** is the attack value.

When porting material that prints a flat damage number (a trap, a breath quoted in hp), convert by the die or treat it as a telegraphed area effect — never paste a legacy save and a legacy damage line and call it done.

Traps have no pool: flat Damage from the die average. Defend with Fuel if you have dice up; take it whole if you don't. A trap is **detect or eat** — scouting buys the telegraph.

Armor and Resistance soak; they never roll

Armor (AC) is what a Burner wears — a flat soak subtracted from every blow before HP. It never enters the exchange as a die.

Monsters do not use AC. Convert module or natural AC into extra HP, or into **Resistance vs weapons** when the creature is famous for its armor (knight, dragon). See [[Burners Referee Guide#Building and Running Monsters]] and [[Burners OSE Conversions]].

Resistance is flat damage reduction against a **named kind** of harm — blades, fire, magic, weapons against famous hide. It comes off every hit of that kind before HP. It is never a **key**: no “only magic weapons can hurt this.” Name the scope, and ideally name a weakness that bypasses it. Wear it down with weight of numbers, or find what it does not resist. A named weakness does not lower Resistance; it **ignores** it. Every Resistance above a point or two **names its cause** — a thing the party can learn and undo. Never fold Resistance into HP.

Twenty militia hacking a high-Resistance thing each land almost nothing while it kills them. That is correct; it is why the village hired Burners.

No plusses on sums. A +n from another game never becomes a bonus added to a roll total. It becomes **enchanted** arms or armor — see [[Burners Referee Magic Items]].

Harm and effect are separate lanes

When a hostile working overruns your defense:

- **Damage** applies overrun to HP 1:1 (then PC AC and Resistance where they apply). **Physical** manifestations — conjured blade, stone shards, dodgeable cone — may be soaked by a Burner's AC after Defend; **non-physical** workings ignore AC. Monsters soak with Resistance only.
- **Control** (charm, sleep, fear, command...) never chips HP. Fully defended: nothing. Defense fell short: the working takes hold — full or partial per the spell and the overrun (Referee's call on edge cases). Recover when the working ends or is broken.

Never both harm and hold from the same working on the same target. OSE *save for half* does not port.

No instant death

Poison, paralysis, petrification, death rays, and energy drain route into subsystems Burners already has:

- a **Defend** to avoid the touch;
- a **lingering Cost** (level in HP per round for level rounds, no further defense);
- a **counting doom** (repeated Defends, each miss a step toward stone);
- **Wounds** and **Shock Checks** (combat-effective), then **help** + **Craft survival** after the fight — see [[Burners Adventure Game#Wounds]];
- a **telegraphed area effect** you Ward (if magic), cover, or eat.

Energy drain does **not** strip levels. A successful drain touch (wight, wraith, and kin) opens a **Wound** even if you are still above 0 HP — you are Wounded for recovery and post-fight survival. No Hour Rest until full HP. If you **die** from that creature's attack (unhelped or failed survival), the **monster's special** may fire — rise as spawn, and so on. Write it on the monster; telegraph it at the table.

Death comes from **failed post-fight survival, unhelped Wounds after a fight**, or a **coup de grace** on a helpless body — not from a single failed save out of combat, and not from classic level loss. The Referee may offer a maiming at the brink instead.

Telegraph the unwinnable

A **monster** area effect — dragon breath, a collapsing ceiling — is often the blow you cannot slip as an ordinary Fuel Defend against a cast total. The Referee telegraphs it ("its chest glows") so cover, eating the quoted damage, or (if the breath is **hostile magic**) a Sorcerer's **Ward** is a **choice**, not a gotcha. Mundane cones and collapsing stone are not Warded.

A **spell** cone or burst uses **Defend** and overrun like any other hostile working.

No gotchas

Burners puts information on the table on purpose. Fuel is face-up. Heat is announced. Threats are telegraphed. The crew chooses with eyes open — they may still choose badly, but they were not ambushed by a rule they could not see.

Warn before the irreversible. If a move will spring a sharp interaction the player may not have clocked, say so, then let them decide. Example: shooting a missile into a melee when the target can use a Burner as **Cover** — Fuel Sparks are already showing. *“Are you sure you want to put that into the press? He’s got a Spark sitting right there.”* Procedure: [[Burners Referee Guide#Cover, Sparks, and shooting into the press]].

Hidden monsters, sealed doors, and lies in the fiction are fair. Hidden *rules* are not.

Route, don’t reinvent

Every die, save, check, and bonus from another game is a **pointer** to a Burners subsystem — not a new mechanic to copy.

Legacy idea	Burners route
Ability check	Approach roll (2d6 + Approach)
Save vs. hazard	Defend (2d6 + Approach) vs Cost
Save vs. spell	Fuel Defend vs cast total ; roll initiative if no fight yet
Save vs. breath (monster)	Area effect — telegraph, ward, cover, or eat it
Save vs. poison	Defend (Craft) to avoid; lingering Cost once it lands
To-hit / THAC0	Deleted — the pool carries the attack
Magic weapon to hit	Resistance + named weakness
+n weapon or armor	Enchanted tiers, extra Fuel die, minor powers
XP for magic items	0 XP — the item is the reward

The full OSE routing tables live in [[Burners OSE Conversions]]. Read a stat block once, write the margin note — HP (folded AC if any), pool (HD + weapon slots), Resistance-if-any — and run it.

What this means at the table

- **Read the moment.** Is the world bending to a clever plan, or is there a price? Pick the engine.
- **Spend dice.** Defense is a resource decision, not a permission check.

- **Name the harm.** Resistance and weaknesses are fiction first; the numbers follow.
- **No gotchas.** Face-up Fuel, announced Heat, telegraphed threats — warn before a sharp rule bites (Cover Sparks into the press), then honor the choice.
- **Telegraph the big hits.** Dragon breath and collapsing ceilings are choices, not surprises sprung cold.
- **Let the dread work.** Lingering Costs and wound severity do the horror; the Referee does not re-roll every round.
- **Face the Heat dial.** Foreshadowing in module text is a raise; preparation is a reduction.
- **Don't double-count dread.** Creature stats and scene Heat are separate levers.

When two rules seem to disagree, the principle wins — then find the subsystem that already implements it.